

ACQLERATE

PM Essentials Template Pack

Your plain-English guide to 5 tools every defense program manager needs

Welcome & Overview

You just downloaded five tools that defense program managers actually use — and that most people spend weeks building from scratch on every new program.

This pack isn't a textbook. It's a set of ready-to-use templates designed for real DoD program environments — the kind where you're juggling cost reports, risk reviews, and stakeholder meetings before your coffee gets cold.

Each tool in this pack solves a specific problem. The RFP Compliance Matrix keeps your proposals from getting thrown out on a technicality. The Risk Register gives your leadership a clear picture of what could go wrong — before it does. The IGCE Calculator saves you from building cost formulas from scratch. The RACI Matrix stops the "I thought you were handling that" conversations. And the PM Briefing Deck gives you a professional template for program reviews instead of starting from a blank slide.

This guide walks you through every tool — what it does, why it matters, what's inside, and exactly how to use it. No jargon. No fluff. Just practical guidance you can apply immediately.

Tool 1: RFP Compliance Matrix

What It Is

A checklist that maps every government requirement in the RFP to a specific place in your proposal. Think of it like a receipt — you want to make sure every item the government asked for has been "checked off" before you submit.

Why It Matters

The number-one reason proposals lose isn't a weak technical approach — it's non-compliance. The evaluator literally can't give you points for something you forgot to address. A missing section, an unanswered requirement, a mislabeled volume — any of these can knock you out before your best ideas even get read.

What's Inside

- Sheet 1: 20 pre-filled DoD RFP requirements (Section L format) with columns for volume, page reference, compliance status (green/yellow/red dropdown), and owner.
- Sheet 2: An instructions guide explaining every column and how to customize it for your RFP.

How to Use It

Step 1 — Read your RFP Section L — the instructions to offerors. This tells you exactly what the government wants.

Step 2 — Add each requirement as a row in the matrix. Be specific — one requirement per row.

Step 3 — Assign an owner and page reference as your proposal sections get written.

Step 4 — Nothing goes to submit review until every row is green. Period.

Tool 2: Risk Register

What It Is

A living spreadsheet that tracks every risk to your program — cost, schedule, technical, and external — with a calculated risk score that tells you which ones need attention right now.

THE ANALOGY

Think of it like a weather forecast for your program. You can't stop the storm, but you can see it coming and prepare. The Risk Register is your forecast — it shows you which risks are building on the horizon and which ones have already passed.

What's Inside

- 15 pre-populated defense program risks covering cost, schedule, technical, and external categories.
- Probability × Impact scoring with auto-calculated risk levels.
- Color-coded heat map (red/yellow/green) so you can see your biggest risks at a glance.
- A 5×5 risk matrix chart for program reviews.

How to Use It

Step 1 — Start with the 15 pre-loaded risks and delete what doesn't apply to your program.

Step 2 — Add your program-specific risks. Think about what keeps you up at night.

Step 3 — Score each one: 1–5 probability, 1–5 impact. The Risk Level column calculates automatically.

Step 4 — Review with your team monthly and update the Status column. Risks change — your register should too.

Tool 3: IGCE Calculator

What It Is

A spreadsheet that calculates the government's estimated cost for your contract — the Independent Government Cost Estimate. It's the government's own math that says "this is what we think this should cost" before they open a single proposal.

THE ANALOGY

Before you hire a contractor to renovate your kitchen, you get your own estimate so you know if their bid is reasonable. The IGCE is the government doing the same thing before they receive proposals. If your bid is wildly above or below the IGCE, it raises flags.

What's Inside

- Labor Estimate tab: 10 Labor Category Descriptions (LCATs) with fully-loaded cost formulas — fringe, overhead, G&A, and fee are already built in.
- ODC & Travel tab: fields for materials, travel, subcontract costs, and other direct costs.
- IGCE Summary tab: rolls everything up automatically across 3 performance years.

How to Use It

Step 1 — Enter your Labor Categories and hourly rates in the Labor tab. The fringe, overhead, G&A, and fee calculations are already built in — just update the rates.

Step 2 — Add materials, travel, and subcontract costs in the ODC tab.

Step 3 — The Summary tab automatically totals everything across 3 years. Export it for your acquisition package.

Tool 4: Stakeholder RACI Matrix

What It Is

A one-page map of who does what on your program. RACI stands for Responsible, Accountable, Consulted, Informed — the four roles any person can play in any activity.

THE ANALOGY

If your program were a flight, the RACI tells you who's flying the plane (Responsible), who owns the aircraft (Accountable), who ATC needs to talk to (Consulted), and who gets notified when you land (Informed). Without it, everyone thinks someone else is flying.

What's Inside

- 25 common DoD program activities pre-mapped across 10 stakeholder roles.
- Color-coded cells: R = teal, A = navy, C = light blue, I = gray.
- Ready to customize with your actual team members and offices.

Letter	Role	What It Means
R	Responsible	Does the work. Hands on keyboard.
A	Accountable	Owns the outcome. Signs off. Only one per activity.
C	Consulted	Gives input before or during the work.
I	Informed	Notified after the fact. Kept in the loop.

How to Use It

- Step 1** — Replace the pre-filled role names with your actual team members or offices.
- Step 2** — Review each activity row — if more than one person has "R", clarify who's actually doing the work.
- Step 3** — Share with your team at program kickoff so everyone knows their lane from day one.

Tool 5: PM Briefing Deck

What It Is

A 12-slide PowerPoint template for your program status review — the kind you'd give to leadership, the program office, or your customer. No more starting from a blank deck at 10 PM the night before a review.

What's Inside

Slide	Content
1	Cover — Program name, date, classification
2	Agenda
3	Executive Summary with traffic light status indicators
4	Program Status overview
5	Schedule performance with SPI callout
6	Cost / EVM with KPI cards
7	Risk Status summary
8	Technical Progress
9	Contractor Performance (CPARS-aligned)
10	Issues & Actions tracker
11	Way Forward — 30/60/90-day look-ahead
12	Backup / Appendix

How to Use It

Step 1 — Update the program name, date, and logo on the cover slide.

Step 2 — Work through each slide left to right. The traffic lights are shapes you can recolor (green/yellow/red) — just right-click and change the fill.

Step 3 — Delete slides you don't need for your specific review type. Not every review needs all 12 slides.

Quick Start Checklist

Not sure where to start? Here's the recommended order. You don't need to use all five tools on day one — but this sequence gets you set up the fastest.

1 Open the RACI first

Know your team. Who's doing what? Get this agreed upon before anything else.

2 Pull up the Risk Register

Know your threats. What could derail your program? Get those risks documented early.

3 Start your IGCE if you're in pre-award

The cost estimate takes time. Don't wait until the last week.

4 Build your Compliance Matrix as soon as the RFP drops

Every requirement gets a row. Every row gets an owner. No exceptions.

5 Use the Briefing Deck for your first program review

You'll look prepared. Because you will be.

Questions? Visit acqlerate.com for tutorials, walkthroughs, and the full Acqlerate template library.